

irregularities and him influencing the bidding process, he shrugged—or tweeted—off the allegations as if the laws of the land and public scrutiny were such banalities meant only for lesser mortals.

The last auction for the IPL franchises in Kochi and Pune set the stage for the unmaking of the Modi myth. In 140 characters—ah, the curse of the tweet—he put an end to the career of his one-time buddy Shashi Tharoor, an amateur in the political whirl of Delhi. Modi's tweet about the sweat equity of Tharoor's lady friend in the Kochi franchise cost the minister of state for external affairs his job. He had to go because questions were asked about ministerial propriety and transparency. As Tharoor went down, he had his tormentor by his tie-end. What was the meaning of Modi's selective leak? Why did he single out the Kochi franchise, which was mentored by Tharoor, a cricket buff, out of his love for his home state? The Government was ready to sacrifice one of its brightest stars but would not let Modi, who in turn was mentored by the mighty Sharad Pawar, a UPA ally, go scot free. Was Kochi the only stain on the IPL? With Finance Minister Pranab Mukherjee's announcement in Parliament that the Government would probe every aspect of the IPL scam, the game was turning politically volatile. And cracks were appearing on the fortresses of the Modi empire. His political benefactors, including the Grand Maratha, would soon abandon him.

Still, Modi, true to his style, stood defiant in the face of the Government's wrath. Even as the team owners seemed to be firmly behind Modi, with Vijay Mallya even going on national television to defend him, income tax officials swooped down on the offices of the IPL franchises Kolkata Knight Riders, Chennai Super Kings, Deccan Chargers and Kings XI Punjab and also on the offices of the companies in-

INTERVIEW | Sharad Pawar

“Lalit Modi often invites trou

Union Agriculture Minister Sharad Pawar spoke with Managing Editor SHANKAR AIYAR. Unruffled by the scandal, the ICC president-elect played with a straight bat to dismiss the allegations as worse than frivolous.

Q. The IPL, a glamorous success story, is now a scandal. Why?

A. There is no doubt that the IPL has been a success, and a global success. It has provided cricketers income stability and given new talent the opportunity to play with the best. Yes, some allegations are being made but I think disproportionate publicity and attention is being given; some of the allegations are not even worth calling frivolous.

Q. There has been speculation

about you and your colleague Praful Patel...

A. Absolute rubbish. I can say this categorically that it's not true. Praful's daughter is working with the IPL, nothing more. And nobody from my family is involved financially with cricket.

Q. There is speculation about tapes of conversation between two ministers and Modi...

A. I do not pay attention to this kind of rubbish. There is a probe going on; let us wait.

Q. But has there been any wrongdoing or not? What do you feel?

A. Government agencies are looking into the allegations and suspicions. I think they should look into all the charges and let all of India know. If



PAWAR WITH MANOHAR

OMAR SIBTAN